

Inferno Quiz 2 • Study Guide • Cantos XIV–XXIII

Literature 11 • Mr. Nesheim • 2026–27

For each place, know four things: **the sin**, **the punishment**, **how the punishment fits the sin** (the contrapasso), and **who Dante meets there**. The line numbers point you to the book. Reread those lines with a pencil in hand.

THE WAY DOWN



PART 1 • PLACE BY PLACE

WHERE • THE SIN	CANTO	WHO YOU MEET	REREAD
The burning sand • violence against God (blasphemy)	XIV	Capaneus	XIV.19–30, 46–72
The burning sand • violence against nature (sodomy)	XV–XVI	Brunetto Latini; three Florentines (Guido Guerra, Tegghiaio Aldobrandi, Iacopo Rusticucci)	XV.16–124 XVI.19–45
The burning sand • violence against art (usury; "art" means human work)	XVII	the usurers, each with a purse hung from his neck	XVII.34–78
The great cliff down to circle 8	XVI–XVII	Geryon, the image of fraud (XVII.7)	XVI.106–136 XVII.1–27, 79–136
Ditch 1 • panders and seducers	XVIII	Venedico Caccianemico; Jason	XVIII.1–99
Ditch 2 • flatterers	XVIII	Alessio Interminei; Thaïs	XVIII.100–136
Ditch 3 • simony (selling church offices)	XIX	Pope Nicholas III	XIX.1–120
Ditch 4 • divination (fortune-telling)	XX	Amphiaraus, Tiresias, Manto	XX.1–99
Ditch 5 • barratry (selling public office)	XXI–XXII	the Malebranche devils; the Navarrese	XXI.16–57 XXII.31–151
Ditch 6 • hypocrisy	XXIII	two friars from Bologna (Catalano and Loderingo); Caiaphas	XXIII.58–72, 103–123

CAREFUL!! Simony (ditch 3) sells CHURCH offices. Barratry (ditch 5) sells PUBLIC offices.

PART 2 • TOPICS TO KNOW

1. **The burning sand.** Reread XIV.19–30. Who lies, who sits, and who keeps moving? What falls on them, and how? Then Capaneus, XIV.46–72: what is his worst punishment, in Virgil's words (63–66)?
2. **Brunetto Latini.** Reread XV.22–124. Who was he to Dante? How does Dante speak to him (82–87)? What does it mean that Dante finds a man he honors in this place?
3. **Geryon.** Reread XVII.1–27. Look at his face, his body, and his tail. Why is this the right image for fraud (XVII.7)?
4. **The hypocrites and Caiaphas.** Reread XXIII.58–72 and 109–123. What do the hypocrites wear, and how do they move? Who is the man staked across the road, and what happens to him? (His words are in John 11:49–50.)
5. **Virgil as guide.** Reread these five moments and say what Virgil does in each: XIV.94–120 • XIX.43–45 • XX.25–30 • XXI.58–87 • XXIII.37–51. Be ready to give two different ways he guides Dante, each with its example.
6. **The Old Man of Crete.** Reread XIV.94–120. What is the statue made of, what is cracked, and where do its tears go?

WORDS TO KNOW

contrapasso • the punishment answers the sin (Dante's own word; you will meet it in XXVIII.142)

usury • lending money at interest

barratry • buying or selling a public office or favor

Malebolge • "evil pouches": the ten ditches of circle 8 (XVIII.1)

simony • buying or selling a church office, after Simon the magician (Acts 8:18–20; XIX.1)

hypocrite • from the Greek word for a stage actor: one who wears a false face